



FIRE crews extinguish flames Tuesday after Russia struck a residential building in Kostiantynivka, Ukraine.

TRUMP: NO U.S. TROOP ROLE IN UKRAINE

President rules out sending a force and says Kyiv is unlikely to regain Crimea.

BY DARLENE SUPERVILLE
AND AAMER MADHANI

WASHINGTON — President Trump on Tuesday offered his assurances that U.S. troops would not be sent to help defend Ukraine against Russia after seeming to leave open the possibility the day before.

Trump also said in a morning TV interview that Ukraine's hopes of joining NATO and regaining the Crimean peninsula from Russia are "impossible."

The Republican president, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky and other European leaders held hours of talks at the White House on Monday aimed at bringing an end to Russia's war against Ukraine. While answering questions from journalists, Trump did not rule out sending U.S. troops to participate in a European-led effort to defend Ukraine as part of security guarantees sought by Zelensky.

Trump said after his meeting in Alaska last week with Russian President Vladimir Putin that Putin was open to the idea of security guarantees for Ukraine.

But asked Tuesday on Fox News Channel's "Fox & Friends" what assurances he could provide going beyond his term that American troops would not be part of the forces defending

Maker of voting machines had 'slush fund,' feds allege

BY REBECCA ELLIS
AND RICHARD WINTON

An election technology firm allegedly overbilled Los Angeles County for voting machines used during the 2020 election and funneled the extra cash into a "slush fund" for bribing government officials, federal prosecutors say in a criminal case against three company executives.

Smartmatic, a U.K.-based voting system company, had bribery embedded as part of its business model,

prosecutors allege in a Florida federal corruption case against company co-founder Roger Alejandro Piñate Martinez and two other company officials.

Prosecutors do not indicate who benefited from the alleged pot of Los Angeles County taxpayer money.

Dean Logan, the county's top voting official, has acknowledged regularly meeting with Piñate, a Boca Raton resident who was charged last year with bribery and money laundering in the Philippines.

That's where executives

are charged with inflating the price of voting machines and using the surplus money to bribe a top election official who could help them land contracts worth \$182 million for the 2016 election.

To secure political favors in Venezuela, Smartmatic employees are accused of fashioning a similar fund to buy a longtime elections official a home with a pool in 2019 as they tried to get a more solid footing in the country, according to an Aug. 1 motion in the Philippine corruption case.

[See **Smartmatic**, A7]

How state plans to boost EVs with no federal help

Restoring subsidies is key among several strategies identified by California officials.

BY TONY BRISCOE

From President Trump's first day back in office, he vowed to unravel California's sway over the nation's auto emission standards by eliminating the state's zero-emission mandates. He made good on that promise in the first several months of his second term.

After a series of controversial congressional votes in May, Trump signed legislation that in effect nullified several of California's auto emission standards, including the state's landmark regulation to ban selling new gas-only cars statewide by 2035.

The "One Big Beautiful Bill," which Trump signed into law in July, will end federal tax credits for zero-

emission vehicles — up to \$7,500 for car buyers — on Sept. 30. Because electric vehicles generally cost more than their gas-powered counterparts, government incentives were critical in encouraging Americans to buy cleaner cars. There is already a slump in statewide sales of electric vehicles.

Without the federal rebates and subsidies to support widespread adoption of electric vehicles, California will almost surely fall short of its greenhouse gas reduction targets and remain in violation of federal air quality standards. Unless, that is, Sacramento steps in, in a big way.

Gov. Gavin Newsom in June signed an executive order reaffirming California's commitment to its emissions goals, and in effect sending state agencies back to the drawing board in light of a newly antagonistic federal government. Their task: to reassert California's climate leadership and identity.

[See **EV**, A8]



AN ELECTRIC vehicle at a Tesla station in Sausalito. There has been a statewide slump in EV sales.

Laughter is dying down in cinemas

Comedy no longer rules the box office. But, funnily enough, the genre has hope.

BY SAMANTHA MASUNAGA

For Hollywood, the state of big-screen comedies has been so grim you almost have to laugh.

There are genres that have dominated the cineplex in recent years — special effects-heavy blockbusters, family films and scream-in-your-seat horror movies.

But comedies? Not so much after the COVID-19 pandemic.

A recent spate of theatrical funnies is trying to change that. This month, studios have released one comedy after another, starting with Paramount Pictures' reboot of "The Naked Gun," starring Liam Neeson and Pamela Anderson, and Walt Disney Co.'s more-than-20-years-later sequel "Freakier Friday," which reunited Jamie Lee Curtis and Lindsay Lohan.

So far, "The Naked Gun" has grossed \$73 million worldwide, while "Freakier Friday" brought in \$86 million. Both received solid reviews from critics — "The Naked Gun" notched a 87% approval rating on aggregator Rotten Tomatoes, while "Freakier Friday" got a 74%.

Next up is Searchlight Pictures' "The Roses," a remake of "The War of the Roses," and Neon's "Splitsville," an original film about messy marriages starring Dakota Johnson.

It's an unusual cadence for a genre that fell out of favor with studios over the last decade or so as onscreen laughs largely moved to streaming. But bringing au-

[See **Comedies**, A11]

THE BEST AND WORST FREEWAYS IN SOUTHLAND

From the easy, breezy 261 to the imperfect 10, The Times ranks them based on speed, crashes and other factors

By Terry Castleman and Shelby Grad

Yes, there was a time when Southern California loved its freeways.

In 1970, British writer and critic Reyner Banham lovingly described them as a "special way of being alive," bringing "on a state of heightened awareness that some locals find mystical." Joan Didion declared they were "the only secular communion Los Angeles has." Stores used to sell a popular postcard showing a handsomely landscaped cloverleaf interchange with the headline "Dig those crazy freeways."

But that was a long time ago, before multihour commutes, freeway chases, road rage, "carmageddon" and the annual Thanksgiving jam on the 405. These days, almost no one "digs" freeways. They tend to judge freeways based on how much pain and stress they bring.

We set out to rank Southern California's freeways and highways once and for all.



Though no metric is perfect, our approach combines some of the most important data points on freeways — average speed of cars, delays, lost productivity and fatalities — to approximate the worst and best stretches of road in Southern California. We also selected specific stretches of freeway to measure, and those may or may not line up with your commute. We used a year of data from 2022, which is the most recent available. For all these reasons, our rankings are subjective, but they represent our best attempt to examine the freeway system.

Our analysis of Caltrans Performance Measurement System data prioritized and gave similar weighting to four main factors:

- Average speed: The number of vehicle miles of travel divided by vehicle hours of travel, or Q, is a common metric in traffic studies.

[See **Freeways**, A6]

Ancestral land returned to tribe

A church turns over a half-acre plot to the San Gabriel Band of Mission Indians.

BY NOAH HAGGERTY

On July 10, a church signed the deeds transferring a half-acre of land hosting a community center in the heart of San Gabriel — less than a mile down the

road from the Mission San Gabriel Arcángel — to an Indigenous tribe's nonprofit.

On paper, it was a relatively ordinary transaction (except maybe for the \$0 price tag); however, for the San Gabriel Band of Mission Indians based in Los Angeles and Orange counties, it was anything but. For the first time in centuries, a piece of their ancestral territory belongs to them.

"There were books when my daughters were in gram-

mar school and high school that stated we were extinct," said Art Morales, an elder and historian in the tribe. To Morales, persevering through that long, painful history is what makes the agreement so significant: The tribe is "basically on the map now."

The lot, previously owned by the Presbytery of San Gabriel — a unit of the Presbyterian Church (USA), one of the largest Presbyterian de-

[See **Land**, A14]



ART Morales, left, is shown with other members of the San Gabriel Band of Mission Indians on Monday.

Menendezes to face parole board

The brothers could get a decision this week in their long pursuit of freedom. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Not all is right in Dodgers' outfield

Dave Roberts is critical of Teoscar Hernández, then meets with Mookie Betts. **SPORTS**, B10

Graffiti Towers remain in limbo

A bankruptcy sale of the tagged downtown buildings continues to drag on. **BUSINESS**, A9

Weather
Sunny.
L.A. Basin: 90/68. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

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